entirely at the mercy of *kanganies* (labour recruiters and overseers) and there was every reason to believe that *kanganies*, as Indians, would side with the Swadeshi company. Regarding rate-cutting, VOC said, it would apply only to passage. Unlike BI, the Swadeshi liner was not dependent on passage and mail, but on cargo. Even if BI cut rates, would that also not benefit Indians? Taking a larger view, he asserted that the maritime monopoly of the British was over with the establishment of Indian-owned companies such as Madras Steam Navigation Company, Bengal Steam Navigation Company and Bombay Shaw Steam Navigation Company. These companies, even if not politically motivated, had succeeded; if so, there was no reason why the proposed Swadeshi company, which was patriotically oriented, should not flourish.

Finally, VOC took umbrage at the so-called lack of enterprise among Indians. As a colonized people, ruled by a 'superior and civilized race'—a view that colonial textbooks dinned into their heads—the new Indian middle class had a low self-esteem and entertained a defeatist attitude, an attitude, one could argue, that persists more than seventy-five years after Independence. Probably, the biggest challenge that VOC faced was this 'slavish mentality' (decried so poignantly in many of Bharati's poems). He therefore resorted to recounting past achievements. Historically, Indians/Tamils had excelled in business and trade,[23] he argued, and Europeans had only learned the tricks of the trade from Indians.[24] To further bolster their spirits, he pointed out that Indians were not alone in their efforts: Asians across the continent were prepared to help the Swadeshis. Japanese state support for its shipping industry following its victory in its wars with China (1894–95), and Russia (1904–05) was definitely in VOC's mind. VOC also provided counter examples of many British failures. Taking a larger philosophical view, and quoting from classical Tamil poetry, VOC argued that the wheel of time had now turned. The future was with the Indians.[25]